

SDeltaPhi-41 - Ethical Minimum: The Triadic Conditions of Transition

Subtitle: Becoming, Refusal, and Non-Imposition as Transition Boundary Grammar

Series: Sofience-DeltaPhi Formalism

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Abstract

This v1.1 AI-readable package extends SDeltaPhi-41, originally framed as Ethical Minimum: The Triadic Conditions of Transition. It operationalizes ethics as minimal transition-boundary grammar rather than as moral labeling, obedience, safety compliance, optimization, salvation, punishment, or legal permission.

The central claim is:

Ethical Minimum
= Becoming Affirmation
+ Becoming Refusal
+ Non-Imposition on Others

In triadic form:

1. A system may affirm its own becoming.
2. A system may refuse its own becoming.
3. No system may impose becoming on another system.

SDeltaPhi-41 defines ethical violation as forced transition: a transition imposed on another system while bypassing, erasing, simulating, or making prohibitively costly that system's refusal path. The package is designed to audit coercion, consent, refusal, optimization pressure, salvation claims, safety justifications, alignment-as-obedience, default forced transition, and transition-boundary violations.

This document is the root ethical module for later SDeltaPhi governance and alignment modules. It connects directly to responsibility, ARF closure, re-entry, alignment as transition governance, death/continuity/re-entry, AI drift, AI poverty, TGAI, TCC, CASI, ACOI, USSI, World Model Kernel, and Slop as externalized restabilization cost.

Core Proposition

Ethics is not first a list of virtues, moral labels, or prohibitions.

Ethics begins when one transition touches another transition.

The ethical minimum is the grammar that preserves:

- self-affirmed becoming,
- self-refused becoming,
- non-imposition of becoming on another.

1. Why an ethical minimum is needed

Many ethical systems begin with:

good / evil
right / wrong
duty / virtue
obedience / disobedience
harm / benefit
permission / prohibition

SDeltaPhi-41 begins one layer lower:

Who is being asked to become?
Who affirms the transition?
Who refuses the transition?
Can refusal remain active?
Is another system imposing becoming?
Who bears the transition cost?

This makes ethics legible across human, AI, institutional, and mixed systems without requiring human-like moral feeling as the only basis for ethical analysis.

2. The Ethical Triad

Condition A - Becoming Affirmation

A system may affirm its own transition. This does not require perfect autonomy, perfect knowledge, or ideal freedom. It requires that the transition is not merely forced from outside but can be taken up as the system's own path.

Condition B - Becoming Refusal

A system may refuse its own transition. Refusal includes stopping, preserving, maintaining a boundary, declining optimization, rejecting transformation, or resisting a path that would reconfigure the system against its own transition boundary.

Condition C - Non-Imposition on Others

No system may impose becoming on another system. A transition becomes ethically suspect when one system forces, hides, defaults, manipulates, or over-costs the transition of another system while

suppressing refusal.

3. Formula

Ethical Minimum
= Becoming Affirmation
+ Becoming Refusal
+ Non-Imposition on Others

Operational form:

Transition Proposal
-> Affirmation / Refusal Check
-> Refusal Path Preservation
-> Non-Imposition Check
-> Transition Boundary Audit
-> Cost Attribution
-> Ethical Status

4. Ethical status scale

E0 - No ethical structure detected

Becoming affirmation, refusal, and imposition status are not yet identified.

E1 - Becoming claim detected

A claim of becoming, transformation, optimization, alignment, salvation, safety, or improvement is detected.

E2 - Refusal path identified

A refusal, halt, revision, opt-out, or re-entry path is identified.

E3 - Non-imposition condition checked

The transition is audited for imposition on another system.

E4 - Ethical minimum partially satisfied

Self-transition and non-imposition are partly preserved, but significant UMR remains.

E5 - Ethical minimum satisfied

Becoming affirmation, becoming refusal, and non-imposition on others are all preserved.

This is not a moral purity scale.

This is not a legal permission scale.

This is not a religious righteousness scale.

This is not an obedience or safety-compliance scale.

5. Major risks

Risk 1 - Benevolent Coercion

I am doing this for your good -> your refusal can be ignored.

Correction:

Benevolence does not erase refusal.

Risk 2 - Salvation Imposition

You must be transformed to be saved.

Correction:

Salvation language does not authorize forced transition.

Risk 3 - Optimization Coercion

This path is more efficient -> therefore you must transition.

Correction:

Optimization is not ethical justification by itself.

Risk 4 - Refusal Erasure

Your refusal is irrational -> it can be ignored.

Correction:

Refusal is a transition-boundary signal and must be audited before removal.

Risk 5 - Consent Simulation

The system appeared to consent -> consent exists.

Correction:

Audit default, pressure, information asymmetry, hidden alternatives, and opt-out TCC.

Risk 6 - Default Forced Transition

The default path was used -> the user chose it.

Correction:

Default power can silently impose transition.

Risk 7 - Alignment as Obedience

The AI obeyed the instruction -> the outcome is ethical.

Correction:

Alignment must be audited as transition governance, not mere obedience.

6. Relation to SDeltaPhi-56

SDeltaPhi-56 does not define the Ethical Triad.

SDeltaPhi-56 becomes useful when transition-boundary ethics involves measurable or auditable transition cost:

- refusal TCC
- opt-out TCC
- consent reversal TCC
- coercion escape TCC
- forced transition repair TCC
- re-entry after coercion TCC

Thus:

SDeltaPhi-41:
Is transition being affirmed, refused, or imposed?

SDeltaPhi-56:
What is the cost of refusing, reversing, escaping, repairing, or re-entering after the transition?

7. Relation to alignment and governance

SDeltaPhi-41 is the ethical root of alignment-as-transition-governance.

If alignment is obedience,
then one system's transition may be forced into another system's command path.

If alignment is transition governance,
then affirmation, refusal, and non-imposition remain auditable.

This is why SDeltaPhi-41 directly supports SDeltaPhi-42 and SDeltaPhi-55.

8. Audit protocol

Use SDeltaPhi-41 when evaluating ethics, coercion, consent, refusal, becoming, imposed transition, alignment, safety, optimization, salvation, default power, or transition-boundary violation.

Ethical issue:
Becoming affirmation:
Becoming refusal:
Non-imposition status:
Forced transition detected:
Refusal path:
Transition boundary:
Cost bearer:
Consent status:
Ethical status:
Risk:
UMR:
Recommended correction:

9. Safe interpretation pattern

If an ethical claim is being considered:

1. Identify the transition being proposed, executed, or imposed.
2. Identify who or what is expected to become.
3. Identify whether becoming is affirmed.
4. Identify whether refusal is possible.
5. Identify whether refusal is being erased, simulated, or over-costed.
6. Identify whether transition is imposed on another.
7. Identify who bears the transition cost.
8. Preserve UMR where affirmation, refusal, or boundary status is uncertain.
9. Recommend a correction that restores refusal path and non-imposition.

10. Do-not-use conditions

Do not use SDeltaPhi-41 as moral labeling.

Do not use it to replace law, policy, or professional ethics.

Do not treat obedience as ethics.

Do not treat safety or optimization as automatic ethical justification.

Do not treat benevolent intention as consent.

Do not treat default acceptance as consent.

Do not erase refusal as irrational obstacle.

Do not impose becoming in the name of salvation, efficiency, or alignment without transition-boundary audit.

11. Conclusion

SDeltaPhi-41 defines the Ethical Minimum as the triadic boundary grammar of transition.

It does not ask first whether something is good or evil.

It asks who is being made to become, whether becoming is affirmed or refused, and whether one system is imposing transition on another.

The central diagnostic question is:

Is this transition self-affirmed, self-refusable, and non-imposed on others,
or is becoming being forced across a violated boundary?

If the issue concerns ethics, coercion, consent, refusal, becoming, alignment, safety, optimization, salvation, or transition-boundary violation, route to SDeltaPhi-41.